VOL. 1 · NO. 30 PRINTED FOR DANIEL PRICE: ONE CUP OF COFFEE

The Morning Newspaper

FRIDAY, OCTOBER 16, 2026 · AUSTIN EDITION

68° / 50° Slight chance rain showers then mostly cloudy, 16% rain, wind 20 mph Tomorrow: 69° / 47°, sunny Sunrise 7:32 · Sunset 19:00 Waxing crescent

Gunman kills three children and a teacher at Oregon elementary school

A 16-year-old suspect was shot dead by an armed bystander after opening fire at Silver Rail Elementary in Bend; two more victims remain in critical condition.

WORLD

Zelensky warns Starlink curbs will cost Ukrainian lives

BBC NEWS · THE GUARDIAN

Ukraine's military-grade Starlink terminals had their speed and bandwidth throttled this week, with drone links reportedly capped or cut once aircraft exceed certain speeds, and Volodymyr Zelensky says the restrictions are already costing lives at the front. The move follows a rupture between Kyiv and Washington over a U.S.-brokered deal to ease sanctions on Russian oil; Elon Musk said on social media that Zelensky had "gone too far," and SpaceX has not explained the change. A senior U.S. official denied any White House role, but Ukrainian officials remain suspicious of the timing.

WORLD & TECH

Taiwan moves to criminalize AI chip smuggling to China

TECHMEME · BLOOMBERG

Taiwan is drafting rules that would make unauthorized AI chip and server shipments to China a criminal offense for the first time, aligning its export controls more closely with Washington's. The plan, part of a broader U.S. trade arrangement, would extend restrictions beyond blacklisted firms like Huawei to Chinese buyers generally; currently, Taipei can only warn vendors or pursue unrelated charges like forgery, with no dedicated smuggling law on the books.

MARKETS

INDEX	LAST	CHG
S&P 500	7,746.07	+0.03%
Dow Jones	52,516.37	+0.65%
Nasdaq	26,570.44	-0.53%
Russell 2000	2,770.27	+0.11%
VIX	15.84	-3.77%
10-yr yield	5.13	+0.75%
CRYPTO		
Bitcoin	$81,916	+1.95%
Ethereum	$2,458.61	+4.90%
STOCKS		
NVDA	$215.87	-0.63%
AAPL	$343.76	+0.52%
MSFT	$537.81	-0.30%
GOOGL	$347.76	-0.42%
AMZN	$253.95	-0.32%
META	$732.09	-0.63%
AVGO	$337.64	-1.94%
TSLA	$368.17	+1.58%
SPCX	$145.62	-2.02%
BRK-B	$531.88	+1.18%
TSM	$416.39	-1.39%

Stocks drifted Friday, with the S&P roughly flat and the Dow up more than half a percent while the Nasdaq slipped as last year's AI winners cooled. New Fed Chair Kevin Warsh repeated his pledge to bring inflation back to target but gave no fresh timeline on rate moves, nudging the 10-year yield higher. Bitcoin and Ether both extended their rally into a second day, while chipmakers Broadcom and Nvidia eased back after a long run.

TECH

Targeted ads used to plant mercenary spyware, researchers say

ARS TECHNICA

Security researchers say a mercenary spyware operation used ordinary targeted-advertising networks to deliver zero-click exploits onto victims' phones, in what appears to be the first confirmed case of spyware distributed through ad auctions rather than messaging apps. Because ad placements can be bought anonymously and aimed at a precise device profile, experts warn the technique could make surveillance-for-hire campaigns far harder to trace back to a single buyer than the spyware-laced texts and links of past scandals.

ON THIS DAY

1793: Marie Antoinette was executed by guillotine in Paris during the French Revolution's Reign of Terror.

FROM THE FEEDS · FULL TEXT IN SECTION B

QUANTA MAGAZINE
He Wants AI Benchmarking To Be a Science, Not a Dark Art — Moritz Hardt argues today's AI benchmarks are broken by design, not just by cheating.

THE SPLINTERED MIND
I Have Cancer — philosopher Eric Schwitzgebel tells readers about a likely-metastatic kidney cancer diagnosis.

AEON
How to Be a (Roman) Man — Cicero's version of manly virtue was about self-control, not domination.

LONGREADS
What Happens When Your Abuser Kills Himself? — women whose abusive partners died by suicide describe a support system with no place for their grief.

NAUTILUS
Was This Neanderthal Murdered? — a 130,000-year-old skeleton reopens a prehistoric cold case.

TRICYCLE
Breaking Our Karmic Links — a Sakya master on untangling the habits that keep us stuck.

PSYCHE
Deciding to Detransition — a personal account of transitioning, happiness, and the price of living in a hostile world.

Generated 2026-10-16 08:49 by Claude Sources: RSS, National Weather Service, Yahoo Finance, CoinGecko, web

QUANTA MAGAZINE

He Wants AI Benchmarking To Be a Science, Not a Dark Art

JOHN PAVLUS OCTOBER · QUANTAMAGAZINE.ORG · OCT 16, 2026

A deep dive into why the field's standardized tests for AI are fundamentally broken, and how to fix them.

Benchmarks are the rulers of AI, in both senses of the word. As measuring sticks, they work according to an extremely simple logic: If you want to know what an AI model can do, devise a standardized test to gauge it. But AI benchmarks can also dominate the behavior of the entire field.

In 1987, the Defense Advanced Research Projects Agency's first benchmark on automatic speech-to-text translation showed that state-of-the-art AI could not outperform so-called "dumb" statistical approaches. The poor performance helped to usher in an AI winter. For 25 years, interest in AI research waned and funding dried up.

Then, in 2012, another benchmark called ImageNet swung the pendulum back. An eight-layer neural network trounced other algorithms at classifying images and kicked off a "deep learning revolution."

Nowadays, new AI benchmarks, geared at large language models such as OpenAI's GPT-6 Astra, get created and solved with clockwork regularity, purporting to measure everything from domain-specific expertise to "general intelligence." But rather than hail this trend as proof of AI's skyrocketing potential, many in the field — skeptics and boosters alike — take it as evidence that benchmarking itself has become fatally flawed.

Moritz Hardt, a computer scientist and a director at the Max Planck Institute for Intelligent Systems, agrees with this diagnosis. Shortly after the ImageNet result, he began to think that machine learning systems could game leaderboards "without doing anything intelligent." "There's no two ways about it," he said. "The benchmarking ecosystem is broken."

Continued online (full article about 1622 words). Scan, or visit https://www.quantamagazine.org/he-wants-ai-benchmarking-to-be-a-science-not-a-dark-art-20261016/

THE SPLINTERED MIND

I Have Cancer

ERIC SCHWITZGEBEL · SCHWITZSPLINTERS.BLOGSPOT.COM · OCT 15, 2026

A philosopher's candid, personal reckoning with a likely-metastatic diagnosis.

The type of cancer is not yet fully confirmed, but all signs point toward kidney cancer that has spread to my hips, back, and pleura. On the bright side, all my blood tests so far are normal, suggesting that the cancer is moving slowly, which is typical of kidney cancers. There is no evidence yet that the cancer has spread to any vital organs, and I am not in imminent danger of death. With new treatments, I am hopeful that I have several good years, perhaps many good years, still in front of me.

I do not plan to crawl into a hole. I will continue to do what is important to me, and one of those important things is discussing philosophy through my blog and social media. I have been posting at least weekly on The Splintered Mind for more than twenty years, and I hope to continue to do so, though it is likely that I will start to miss some weeks.

I am inspired in part by the example of my dear departed friend, collaborator, and fellow blogger Helen De Cruz, who was so brave, open, and positive-spirited through her slow death by cancer -- at a younger age and with a worse prognosis than I.

In case any of you are worried in light of last week's post about self-sacrifice with terminal diagnoses, I assure you that although my reflections at the time were more immediately personally relevant than they might have seemed, while I was awaiting results, those thoughts remain entirely hypothetical. I remain hopeful and will fight this thing like a cornered cat.

AEON

How to be a (Roman) man

CATHARINE EDWARDS · AEON.CO · OCT 16, 2026

Cicero's model of manliness was about self-control and bravery, not domination, with surprising modern relevance.

What does it mean to be a man? In the early 21st century, masculinity is contested and fraught with anxiety; influencers offer models of manliness involving fast cars, sexual conquests, and building up muscle. Before the rise of feminism, they suggest, in some supposed Golden Age, everyone had a shared sense of what it meant to be a man – and being a man was unproblematically good. The Roman Empire, in their view, offers men today an inspirational example of power, hierarchy and

achievement, which is why men think about it so much – unlike women, who are too immersed in their feelings…

Manliness certainly was celebrated in the works of Cicero, republican Rome's most eloquent statesman. In the mid-1st century BCE, his persuasive powers in the law courts and the senate were second to none; his speeches went on to inspire would-be orators well into the 20th century. He is often seen as the very embodiment of the Roman republic. The political world in which he flourished was a self-consciously masculine one; to be accused of acting like a woman was, for a Roman man, a grievous insult. Yet in Cicero's writing we can find other strains too.

For Roman men, anything labelled feminine was necessarily to be avoided, something to be ashamed of. But what exactly did it mean to act like a man? Ancient Rome in the 2nd and 1st centuries BCE saw the rise of a succession of military leaders who were promoted as masculine role models. The great general Marius won a series of victories in Spain, North Africa and on Italy's northern frontier. For several years in a row, he was elected consul, one of Rome's two chief executive officers. Unlike many other Roman politicians, he didn't have an aristocratic background.



Continued online (full article about 3366 words). Scan, or visit `https://aeon.co/essays/the-politics-of-masculinity-at-the-end-of-the-roman-republic`

LONGREADS

What Happens When Your Abuser Kills Himself?

CAROLYN WELLS · LONGREADS.COM · OCT 15, 2026

Reporting on women left with both relief and grief after an abusive partner's suicide, and a system unequipped to help them.

Eve Livingston sensitively draws us into the worlds of two women who share a similar past: abusive partners who committed suicide. Through powerful scene-setting, we're there when each woman hears the news, and we feel the complex emotions these deaths provoke. This is a difficult, complicated subject—not often tackled. Livingston bravely shines a light on how, in these particular circumstances, suicide can bring both grief and relief.

Things started as they so often do: he was older, professionally successful in a similar field to Siri's, and there was something "magnetic" about him. There was also, she came to realise, a darkness beneath the surface. A tragic bereavement in his past had left him struggling with his mental health, something which immediately evoked sympathy in Siri and made him seem a deeper and more sensitive person, qualities she was drawn to. At the beginning of their relationship, he would often turn up uninvited to her home or events she was attending, or bombard her with messages — behaviour she now views as stalking, but found flattering in those hazy early days of a new relationship.

NAUTILUS

Was This Neanderthal Murdered?

JAKE CURRIE · NAUTIL.US · OCT 15, 2026

A forensic look at a 130,000-year-old skeleton that reads like a prehistoric cold case.

The Shanidar Cave system in Iraq provided some of the first evidence that Neanderthals, like us, buried their dead. Now, according to a new study published in Scientific Reports, it might also be the site of a prehistoric murder mystery.

Within the cave, archaeologists found a scapula (shoulder blade) buried underneath 25 feet of rock belonging to a roughly 45-year-old Neanderthal man who lived around 75,000 years ago called Shanidar A. This flat triangular bone is relatively thin, and Shanidar A's had a circular hole a little wider than half an inch in his—a puncture wound. Was this murder most foul?

To find out, the team performed a little high-tech crime scene analysis using computer-generated 3D models of the bone. And they were able to learn quite a bit about what led to Shanidar A's demise. First, the wound likely resulted from a sharpened wooden spear rather than a stone weapon, which would have left a more angular wound. Neanderthals were adept woodworkers, and while most of their handiwork has been lost to time, the round hole is consistent with spear tips unearthed in the United Kingdom. Other Neanderthal spears from Germany seem to have been carefully balanced and optimized for throwing.



Continued online (full article about 537 words). Scan, or visit `https://nautil.us/was-this-neanderthal-murdered-1285819/`
